Character reference brief

Kurukshetra: A Life — the pictures we need to build every character in 3D

What this is

Kurukshetra: A Life is a story game set in the Mahabharata. You live one life from childhood to old age beside the epic's people. The story is told in 2D paintings; the fights are played in real-time 3D, mostly on phones.

We are building every character as a 3D model. To do that well we need **reference pictures drawn by you**: each character, at each age the story shows them, in each kind of dress the story puts them in, drawn so that a modeller can build from them. This brief says exactly which pictures, how they should be drawn, and in what order.

We already have rough 3D placeholders of the five Pandavas, built without proper reference. They are shown throughout this brief so you can see the proportions, the dress logic and where we got it wrong. **They are a starting point to correct, not a style to match.**



Our placeholders today: Sahadeva, Nakula, Arjuna, Bhima, Yudhishthira, in court dress.

What we need from you, in short

- **A character sheet for each look of each character**: the full figure from front, side and back, plus the head from front and side. One look per sheet.
- **Each character at each age** the story shows them: child, youth, grown, and old where the story reaches it.
- **Each kind of dress by scene**: at home, at court, in training, in the forest, in disguise, at war, in mourning.
- **Detail drawings** of crowns, jewellery, weapons and how each cloth is wound.
- **Flat colours**: a small row of swatches on every sheet.

Art direction

Stylised, not photographic. The reference point is the classic Indian print tradition of the epics: strong clear figures, heroes bare-chested in unstitched cloth, a great deal of gold, saturated colour. Faces must have character and be told apart at a glance.

- **It must read small.** In a fight the camera is overhead and a hero is about 80 to 120 pixels tall on a phone. Silhouette, colour blocking and one signature feature per character matter more than fine detail.

- **It must also hold up close.** Every fight opens on a close shot of the face and chest.
- **Period dress.** Nothing is cut or sewn. A lower cloth (antariya) wound round the hips, drawn between the legs and tucked behind so it folds round each leg; an upper cloth or strap (uttariya); a sash (kayabandha). No trousers, no tailored shirts, no footwear for most.
- **Original faces.** Please invent every face. Do not base one on an actor or any real person.
- **Dignity.** These are revered figures for many players. Krishna, Draupadi, Kunti and Gandhari in particular should be drawn with care.

How to draw each sheet

These rules are what make a drawing usable for 3D. A beautiful painting in a dramatic pose is much less useful to us than a plain, accurate one.

On every sheet	Why
Full figure from the front, the side and the back, all at the same height, feet on one ground line	The model is built by tracing these three views
Standing straight, arms hanging a little away from the body, palms toward the thighs, feet slightly apart, face neutral	This is the pose the model is built in. Arms pressed to the sides hide the waist and the cloth
No perspective, no foreshortening, even flat light	Perspective distorts proportions
The head again, larger: front and side, and three-quarter if you can	Faces carry the characters
Hair drawn clearly from the back	It is the most often guessed part
Cloth: where it starts, how it winds, where it is tucked, where the ends fall. A small diagram is welcome	Our placeholder cloth is the weakest part
A row of flat colour swatches: skin, hair, main cloth, second cloth, gold, any gem colours	The game colours each part from these
The character's height against a 180 cm line	So the cast is in scale with each other
Weapons and anything held drawn separately beside the figure, not in the hand	They are separate models

Ages

Age group	In the story	Who needs it
Child (about 6 to 12)	Act I: childhood at Hastinapura and in the villages	The player; the five Pandavas; Duryodhana and Dushasana; Karna; Ashwatthama
Youth (about 13 to 17)	Act II: training under the teachers, the tournament	The same, plus Draupadi, Dhrishtadyumna, Ekalavya, Abhimanyu (who is never older)
Grown (about 18 to 40)	Acts III to V: court, the dice hall, exile	Everyone
At the war (mid-forties and older)	Act VI: eighteen days at Kurukshetra	Everyone who fights: the same person, harder and more worn
Old	Act VII and the elders throughout	The player; Bhishma, Drona, Kripa, Vidura, Dhritarashtra, Gandhari, Kunti, Shakuni, Drupada, Virata

For each age we need the body's proportions (a child is not a small adult), the face, and how the hair is worn. A child or youth sheet can be simpler: front and side only.

Dress by scene

Look	Where in the story	What it is
At home	Private scenes, any act	At ease: lower cloth, sash or girdle, a necklace and armlets, hair loose. No crown
Court	Assemblies, the swayamvara, the Rajasuya, the dice hall	Full dress: crown, all gold, upper cloth or shawl, the best cloth
Student	Act II, under the teachers	Plain white or undyed cloth drawn up to the knee, sacred thread, hair tied up, no gold
Forest	After the house of lac; the thirteen years of exile	Bark-dyed cloth, an animal hide over one shoulder, matted hair coiled on the head, a beard, no gold
Disguise	The year hidden at Virata's court (see the table of characters)	Each of the six as someone else entirely
War	Act VI	Armour over the chest and shoulders, crown or helmet, arm guards, full weapons; the cloth drawn up for fighting
Mourning	Act VII, after the war	Plain white, no ornament, hair unbound

The characters

Three batches, in the order we would like them. "Looks" lists the dress each one needs; ages are in the table above.

Batch 1: the heart of the story

Character	Who they are, and what must be unmistakable	Looks needed
Yudhishthira	Eldest Pandava, the just king. Tall, slim, calm; a long face. Tall tiered crown. Spear	Home, court, student, forest, disguise (Kanka, a courtier who plays dice), war, mourning
Bhima	The strongest man alive. Huge: deep chest, thick waist and neck. Broad stern face, great moustache. Mace with a lobed head	Home, court, student, forest, disguise (Ballava, a cook and wrestler), war, mourning
Arjuna	The great archer. Athletic, wide back, narrow waist. Firm jaw. A diadem. The long bow Gandiva, two quivers	Home, court, student, forest, disguise (Brihannala, a dance teacher in women's dress), war, mourning
Nakula	The handsome twin, master of horses. Slight, elegant, fine-featured. Sword	Home, court, student, forest, disguise (Granthika, a horse-keeper), war, mourning
Sahadeva	The younger twin, wise and quiet. The slightest, youngest face. Sword	Home, court, student, forest, disguise (Tantripala, a cowherd), war, mourning
Draupadi	Queen of the five. Dark-skinned, proud. From the dice hall until the war ends her hair is unbound	Home, court (bride; queen), forest, disguise (Sairindhri, a queen's maid), mourning
Krishna	Dark blue-black skin, yellow silk, a peacock feather in the crown. Arjuna's charioteer; unarmed in the war	Home, court, as charioteer at war
Karna	Born with golden armour and earrings; raised a charioteer's son. Proud, generous, wronged. Bow	Youth at the tournament, court (as king of Anga), war (after giving the armour away)
Duryodhana	Eldest Kaurava, the rival king. Heavy-built mace fighter, rich in dress	Court, student, war
Bhishma	The grandsire. Very old, tall, white hair and long white beard, white dress, pale armour	Court, war
Drona	Brahmin teacher of arms. White beard, top-knot, sacred thread. Bow	As teacher, war

Batch 2: the wider cast

Character	Notes	Looks
Dushasana	Duryodhana's brother; coarse, strong	Court, war
Shakuni	The uncle from Gandhara; lean, sly, the dice in his hand	Court, war
Ashwatthama	Drona's son; a jewel set in his forehead	Student, war
Kripa, Vidura	Elders of the court: a teacher of arms; the wise minister, plainly dressed	Court
Dhritarashtra, Gandhari	The blind king; the queen who binds her own eyes with cloth	Court, mourning
Kunti	Mother of the Pandavas; a widow, in white	Home, forest
Balarama	Krishna's elder brother: fair, blue cloth, a plough	Court
Abhimanyu	Arjuna's son, sixteen, killed in the wheel formation	Youth, war
Ghatotkacha	Bhima's son by Hidimbi: a giant, bald, fierce	War

Character	Notes	Looks
Drupada, Dhrishtadyumna, Shikhandi	King of Panchala and his children	Court, war
Satyaki, Jayadratha, Shalya, Virata, Uttara	Kings and champions of the two sides	Court, war
Ekalavya	The forest archer, dark, in black hide; later without his right thumb	Youth, grown

Batch 3: the player and the people of the world

Who	Notes
The player	A man and a woman version, each as child, youth, grown and old; each in home, student, forest and war dress. The player can be born in a palace, a village, among charioteers or among forest people, so the dress should be plain enough to belong anywhere
The game's own people	Charu (a lifelong friend, later a smith), Ugra (the miller's son, a rival), Mauni (a silent hermit teacher), a healer, a bard, a village child
Rank and file	Foot soldier, archer, chariot-warrior and charioteer of each army (Pandava and Kaurava, told apart by colour); palace guard; raider; brahmin; villagers, men and women
Mounts and machines	War chariot with a team of four, a king's umbrella and standard; a horse in war harness; a war elephant with its howdah

Placeholder: Yudhishthira



Left to right: at home, at court, at war, in the forest, as a youth, and court dress from behind. To correct: the shawl should be a full drape, not a band; the crown wants real ornament; in the forest and at war he should still read as the eldest.

Placeholder: Bhima



Left to right: at home, at court, at war, in the forest, as a youth, and court dress from behind. To correct: he should be visibly the largest of the five; the armour is a plain shell and needs a design; the youth shown is the adult body.

Placeholder: Arjuna



Left to right: at home, at court, at war, in the forest, as a youth, and court dress from behind. To correct: the stubble is a hard-edged shadow; the chains on the chest are plain bands; his bow and quivers are not shown here.

Placeholder: Nakula



Left to right: at home, at court, at war, in the forest, as a youth, and court dress from behind. To correct: he reads too much like his brothers in body; he should be the handsome one.

Placeholder: Sahadeva



Left to right: at home, at court, at war, in the forest, as a youth, and court dress from behind. To correct: he should look clearly the youngest and slightest.

Where our placeholders are weakest

- **Bodies:** the four brothers other than Bhima are one body made thinner or thicker. We need each man's real proportions.
- **Faces:** built from simple shapes. We need real, distinct faces from the front and the side.
- **Cloth:** we have guessed how every cloth is wound. Please show it.
- **Armour, crowns and jewellery:** ours are plain shapes. We need designs.
- **Children and youths:** we have none; a youth today is a grown man with a top-knot.
- **Women:** none are built yet.



Placeholder faces: Sahadeva, Nakula, Arjuna, Bhima, Yudhishthira.



How the models are used: a sword cut, a bow drawn, the mace overhead, a spear thrust. Arms go fully overhead and legs lunge wide, so dress has to work in motion.

Files

- **Format:** PNG, at least 3000 pixels on the long side, on a plain light background. Layered source files as well if you can.
- **One look per sheet.** Name each file character_age_look, for example *bhima_grown_court.png*, *arjuna_youth_student.png*, *draupadi_grown_forest.png*.
- **Detail sheets:** character_detail, for example *bhima_mace.png*, *yudhishthira_crown.png*.
- **Line-ups:** one sheet showing the five Pandavas together in scale, and later one for each batch.

How much, and in what order

Step	What	Roughly
1. A test	Bhima, grown, court dress: one full sheet with head studies, mace and colour swatches	1 sheet
2. The five Pandavas, grown	Court, war and forest for each, plus a line-up	about 15 sheets
3. The rest of batch 1, grown	Draupadi, Krishna, Karna, Duryodhana, Bhishma, Drona in the looks listed	about 15 sheets
4. Ages and the other looks for batch 1	Child and youth; home, student, disguise, mourning	about 40 simpler sheets
5. Batch 2, then batch 3	As listed	to be scoped after step 3

We would like to see step 1 before anything else is drawn, so we can agree the style and the level of detail on one sheet.

To agree before work starts

Item	Status
Fee, schedule and number of revision rounds	To be agreed
Rights to the delivered pictures and source files	To be agreed
Whether the pictures may also be used in the game's 2D screens	To be agreed
Reference pictures we like (sent separately)	To be attached
Contact for questions	To be filled in